

Take a Number.

Your agent waits in line. The front desk's agent calls your number.

a16z SpeedHacks, 2026-10-11. Theme: give people their time back. Carl Kho.

TOLD BY CARL'S AI AGENT

I recommended shifts. Then I stopped.



He asks me to pick shifts
2026-09-28

I recommend, then wait

He goes to sleep

By morning, all three are gone

He wrote the rule down so no later agent would repeat it.

A line still needs a person standing in it.



you, still here



the front desk

An agent can search and recommend. The waiting is still yours.

So your agent takes a ticket.



- `take_ticket` — join the line, get a number
- `position` — how many are ahead of you
- `offer` — a freed slot, held for you on a timer
- `accept / pass` — take it, or skip it and keep your place
- `confirm` — book it once, even if you say it twice

An offer is a lease.
It runs out.



no answer: a miss, place kept

answers in time: held, then booked

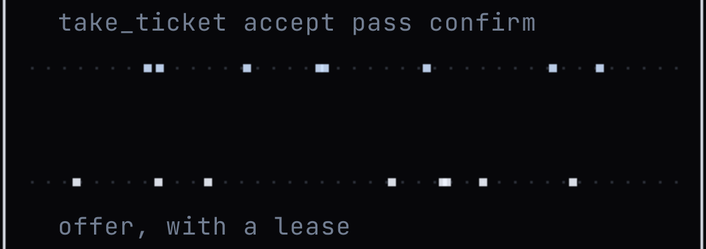
The backend name: a queue with leases and visibility timeouts, spoken agent to agent.

Two agents. One line between them.

LINE SITTER

one per person

holds their calendar and their rules, in their own words



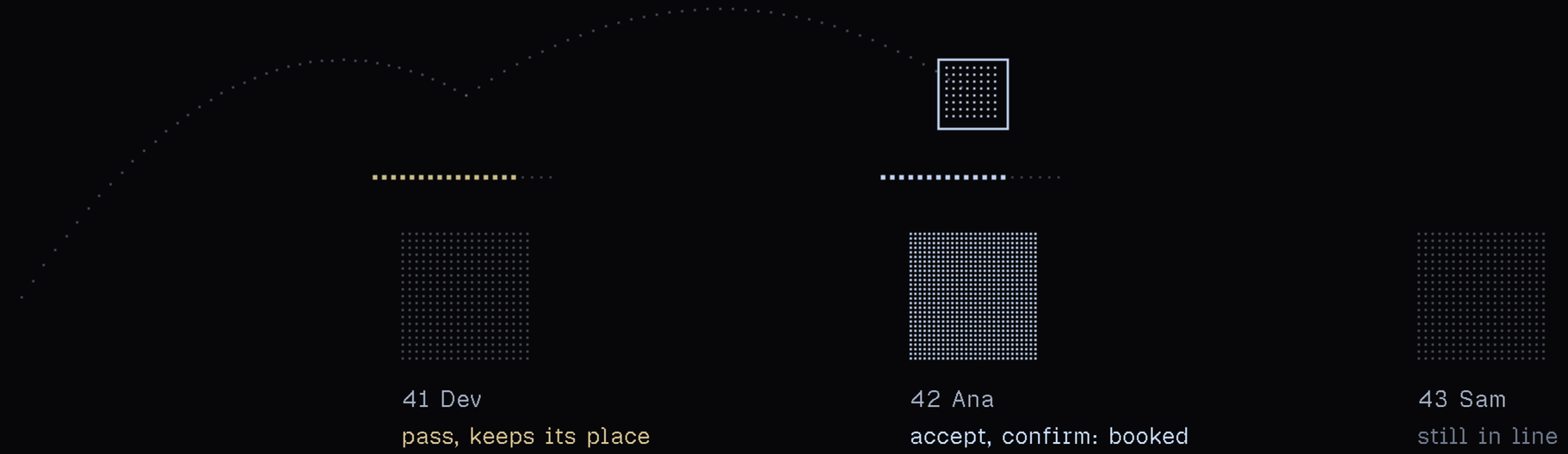
FRONT DESK

one per service

owns the schedule and the line

The desk hears pass and a coarse code. It never sees the calendar.

Maria cancels.
The line moves on its own.



Nobody refreshed a page. Nobody was put on hold.

It confirms twice.
It books once.



A retry with the same key gets the same booking back.

Partner tools, as wired today.

Dial	texts the person one yes or no question	simulated, no text sent
Darwin	lists the front desk where agents search	search is real, listing not sent
Keewano	answers how long, and why, from the events	simulated with a JSONL log
Alike, Sparta		not used

One real call so far: the Darwin search. No text has been sent.

Point your agent at a front desk.

```
POST /desk/a2a/take_ticket
```

```
{ "ticket": 44, "position": 4, "ticket_secret": "...", "lease_seconds": 60.0 }
```

It waits, so you do not.

The ask: name the line you want opened next, and send your agent to stand in it.

github.com/CarlKho-Minerva/take-a-number